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# Uber Clean:
## Creating an Uber for Laundry

At the end of 2021, Uber was evaluating a growth opportunity in laundry and dry-cleaning services.* Uber, the world's leading ride-sharing company, was recovering from a dramatic revenue decrease caused by the COVID-19 pandemic that began in 2020. In the three months ended September 30, 2021, the company reported gross bookings of $23.1 billion, an increase of 57% year-over-year, and 1.64 billion trips, up 39% from the previous year. Uber Eats, its meal-ordering and delivery platform, reported gross bookings of $12.8 billion (up 50% year-over-year).[1]

The company was contemplating creating Uber Clean as an "Uber for laundry." The proposed service would combine Uber's ride-sharing and delivery network with laundering establishments to offer cleaning on demand. In partnership with Tide Cleaners, a venture owned by the consumer product giant Procter & Gamble (P&G), Uber Clean would pick up soiled laundry and deliver it cleaned and pressed to customers in the United States.

The success of Uber Clean would rely heavily on generating insights into consumers' laundry and fabric care behaviors and their receptivity to an on-demand laundry service. These consumer insights would help define the target personae, the customer journey map, and the digital marketing content strategy for Uber Clean.

* This case describes a hypothetical opportunity using fictitious data and content. Neither Uber nor Procter & Gamble was involved in the development of the case or its accompanying teaching note

1 "Uber Announces Results for Third Quarter 2021," accessed December 12, 2024, https://investor.uber.com/news-events/news/press-release-details/2021/Uber-Announces-Results-for-Third-Quarter-2021/.

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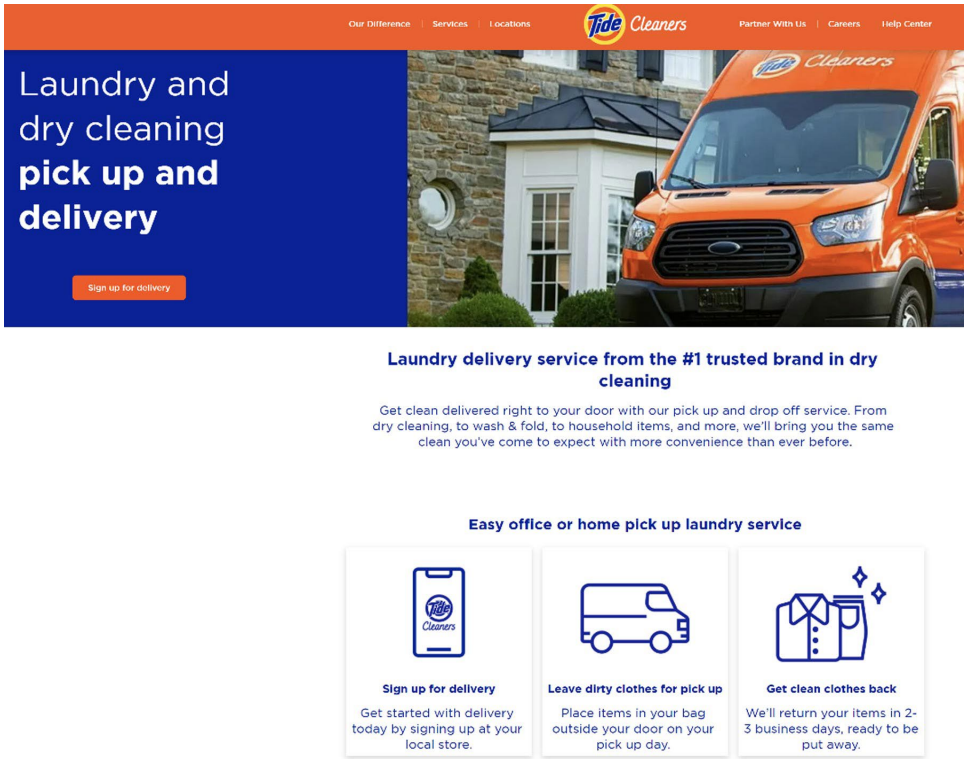
## The Uber Clean Concept

Uber Clean would launch as an extension of the Tide Cleaners laundry and dry-cleaning business. Leveraging the brand equity of its market-leading laundry detergent, P&G opened its first Tide Cleaners stores in 2010; by the end of 2021, more than 180 stores were operated by franchise owners in 24 states. Tide Cleaners also offered wash-and-fold services on dozens of college campuses and thousands of drop-off lockers nationwide. The service required customers to download an app, create an account, bring their dry cleaning or laundry to one of its drop boxes, (located primarily in high-density apartment buildings, offices, and storefronts), place it in the box, and lock it with a code. Customers could track and manage the process through the mobile app. When their laundry and dry cleaning were ready, they were notified by text and email, and the customers used a security code to pick up the items from lockers.

Tide Cleaners customers were happy with the quality of the cleaning, but they found it inconvenient to pick up and drop off their laundry. Although P&G was working hard to expand the number of Tide Cleaners touchpoints, it was still bothersome for customers. Tide Cleaners created a laundry delivery service for offices and homes in response to this pain point. (See **Figure 1** for the company's website.) Customers could sign up for delivery, leave dirty clothes in a Tide Cleaners bag outside their door, and get their clothes back in two or three business days.

**Figure 1:** Tide Cleaners Website




*Source:* Tidecleaners.com.



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The laundry delivery service was convenient for customers, but it was expensive and inefficient; vans and drivers were required to serve customers spread over large distances. Utilization was low, particularly in new markets. Moreover, Tide Cleaners was designed around a core competence in cleaning, not logistics.

Enter Uber as a partner. As before, consumers would place their dirty laundry in a Tide Cleaners laundry bag and leave it at the front door. However, instead of contacting Tide Cleaners, customers would notify Uber Clean, who would send an Uber driver to pick up the laundry. Uber drivers then would collect the clean laundry from Tide Cleaners locations and drop it off at customers' homes.

The Uber Clean concept paralleled the development of Uber Eats, which outsourced takeout meal delivery service from restaurants. Such a partnership allowed restaurants to focus on preparing food instead of managing a delivery service. Similarly, Uber Clean would allow laundry service providers to focus on cleaning and free them from delivery hassles. And Uber already had many more drivers than Tide Cleaners could afford to hire and equip.

Like Uber Eats, the Uber Clean service would increase the capacity utilization of the Uber driver network. An attractive feature of Uber Clean for Uber drivers was that laundry could be picked up and dropped off at any time, as opposed to meals or rides, which, for the most part, were scheduled for specific times. Therefore, Uber drivers could schedule Uber Clean trips during off-peak hours (10 a.m. to noon and 2 p.m. to 4 p.m.) when demand for rides and meal deliveries was lower.

Uber and P&G would share Uber Clean revenues, and Uber, in turn, would share revenues with its drivers.

## Customer Benefits

The Uber Clean service offered the following benefits to consumers:

- **Time savings**: Uber Clean would take care of laundry cleaning and ironing, which are usually done by consumers at home, as well as transporting to and from dry-cleaning establishments.
- **Convenience**: Customers could request pickups and drop-offs even when they were not at home.
- **Personalization**: Users of the service could customize their orders, such as requesting eco-friendly cleaners or stain removal.
- **Quality**: Customers would get high-quality cleaning from Tide Cleaners' professionals, backed up by Tide's quality guarantee. Tide Cleaners used GreenEarth® Cleaning solvent, a superior cleaning agent that was better for the environment.



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# Competition

Uber Clean would not be the first entrant in the on-demand laundry business. Several startup companies offered similar services.

## *Rinse* (www.rinse.com)

The US market leader, Rinse aimed to be a one-stop shop for all garment care needs. Its services included dry clean/launder and press; wash and fold; and hang dry. Rinse sent a company "valet" to the home with everything customers needed to get started, including personalized Rinse bags. Customers filled the bags and confirmed the delivery date and cleaning preferences with their Rinse Valet. Rinse then texted customers to tell them when the valet would arrive with the clean clothes.

Rinse also offered Rinse Drop, a service for customers who might not be home for pickups or drop-offs. Rinse became the largest laundry delivery service nationwide by making multiple acquisitions, including Washio in 2016, Cleanly's San Francisco operations in 2019, OffToYou in 2020, and Dryv, a Chicago-based dry-cleaning and laundry provider in November 2020.

## *Laundry Care* (www.laundrycare.biz)

Laundry Care was founded in 2009 by Danielle Balog, a mother who wanted to earn extra income without sacrificing time with her family. By 2019, the company had agreements with over one hundred cleaning providers in 46 US cities. The company charged for wash-and-fold by the bag. Pickup and delivery were free, and customers could choose from same-day, one-day, and two-day turnaround times with customization options. Busy customers could schedule pickups while they were away from home.

## *Delivery.com* (www.delivery.com)

Founded in 2004, Delivery.com offered on-demand food, alcohol, and laundry by connecting consumers to local businesses. Unlike other competitors, Delivery.com was a marketplace platform, so it did not clean or deliver the laundry. It merely functioned as a middleman between users and laundry service providers.

# Differentiation

The competitive landscape in laundry delivery services mirrored the landscape in meal delivery services. Rinse was the equivalent of DoorDash, offering a dedicated team of delivery providers, and Delivery.com was like GrubHub, relying on providers to deliver the laundry. Uber Clean, when launched, would be like UberEats in the meal delivery space in that it managed delivery through its Uber driver network.



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Uber Clean aimed to differentiate itself from competitors in three ways:

- **Uber network**: Uber could leverage its network of hundreds of thousands of drivers to provide cost-effective pickup and drop-off service.
- **Tide Cleaners partnership**: Laundry service providers were often small mom-and-pop shops with uncertain and variable quality. Uber Clean would have the brand name and the expertise of Tide Cleaners behind it to provide a trusted and reliable customer experience.
- **Analytics and AI**: Uber had strong capabilities in artificial intelligence and machine learning that the company could use to optimize the laundry service, including scheduling, route optimization, personalization, and design of consumer promotions.

Uber believed consumers would be interested in an on-demand laundry service from two trusted brands—Uber and Tide—that would pick up, clean, and deliver laundry right to their door.

## *Your Assignment*

Your task is to conduct research and perform customer analysis to develop the Uber Clean concept further. Your deliverables are:

- **Customer insights**: What customer insights can you offer Uber Clean management? Suggest some online sources—forums, communities, or social network sites—that the Uber Clean team might use for social media listening. Use your social networks to gain insights into how people do laundry and what they think about the Uber Clean concept. You could also sign up for one of the laundry services, including Tide Cleaners, to personally experience it. How would you use online ethnography or online surveys to gain insights? Summarize your analysis in four to five key customer insights.
- **Target persona**: Based on your customer insights, recommend the primary persona that Uber Clean should target. Describe the target persona in terms of demographics, geography, motivations, behaviors, pain points, and digital media consumption behaviors.
- **Customer journey map**: What are the steps in the customer experience of laundry and dry cleaning? Create a customer journey map for the experience. At each stage of the customer journey, define the activities customers perform, their needs, the information they need, their pain points, and how Uber Clean can innovate on the customer experience.
- **Service features**: What features should Uber Clean offer? What should be the most prominent features of the Uber Clean mobile app? What content from the Tide Cleaners website should be included in Uber Clean's mobile app? Should the Uber Clean app be integrated into the Uber app, or should it be a standalone app?



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